



of other occupied peoples.

After Independence, the new leaders wrote history in their own image, and set about uniting the country in a way it never had been united before. Jinnah's role in the nationalist movement, and the fact that his demand for Pakistan had been precipitated by the failure of the Congress to cut a deal with the Muslim League in the 1930s, or to recognise his representative importance, was edited away. Further historical elision was required too: it became necessary to pretend that the Muslim invasions of earlier centuries had been undertaken in order to contest political space and bring kebabs, qawwali and ice to the people of Hindustan. A reading of victorious contemporaneous texts gives a rather different impression, suggesting that conquering foreign lands and destroying idolaters' temples was a virtue in itself, and that the soldiers of Mahmud of Ghazni, Babur or Aurangzeb bore little resemblance to Swedes in blue helmets.

Except for foreigners and a handful of academics, everyone knows this in private, but a situation has developed over time whereby it is difficult to say so publicly for fear of sparking a return to the days of violence, or encouraging the zealots who want to create an exclusively Hindu *rashtra*. More than half a century after Independence, with the raw wound still exposed and unhealed—in Kashmir, in Gujarat, through the lack of proper Muslim representation in the police or the civil services, and in the failure to normalise relations with Pakistan—history cannot be faced squarely in case a genie is unleashed. The attempt by the NDA government to rewrite school textbooks was in part a response to this imbalance, but it was handled so badly and so crankishly that it made matters worse. The idea that an archaeological dig beneath the foundations of a mosque at the birthplace of a mythological figure might, if successful, provoke some sort of national revelation or realignment indicates the scale of the existing problem.

Creating an idea of shared nationhood in a fissiparous land was not the only abstract achievement of the Nehruvian era. Unlike China, India did not exist previously as a coherent administrative whole. It is often forgotten that no more than one-third of India's landmass was ever under British control. Thanks to the ruthless brilliance of Sardar Patel, the princely states were eradicated and their territory integrated into the union; Indira Gandhi's abolition of the privy purses in 1969 was only a sequel to an earlier revolution. Healthcare, national identity, education—all these things became part of the state's purpose, and with one-party rule lasting over



A NATION REBORN: Bharatmata as the idea of India

The economic boost of the last 10 years has engineered a propulsion that has changed the way Indians think about themselves. They now have a chance to shape their destiny.

several decades, it was not fanciful to imagine that India could be recreated in a new image. Schoolchildren continue to be taught that the country comes before everything else, and that an individual's primary allegiance should be to the nation rather than to religious, regional or caste identity. It is a kind of brainwashing, but has been remarkably effective, and underpins both India's current unity and its recent economic rise.

A contrast might be drawn with Britain, where immigration after the Second World War has boosted the non-white population from 25,000 to 4.6 million. Successive governments decided to avoid active integration: it was seen as, well, un-British to demand that people become British if they wanted to hold a British passport. Under the policy of multiculturalism that is now being abandoned, it was accepted that each new community could go its own way and create miniature versions of the society it had left behind. Postcolonial guilt or uncertainty had placed Britain in a much weaker position, in relation to its own citizens, than India. Ideas of